



Juniper is powerfully antiseptic in the urinary tract.

in the treatment of chronic arthritis, gout, and rheumatic conditions. Applied externally as a diluted essential oil, it has a slightly warming effect on the skin and is thought to promote the removal of waste products from underlying tissues. Juniper also stimulates menstruation and tends to increase menstrual bleeding.

Related Species Oil of Cade is produced from *J. oxycedrus* and is applied to treat skin rashes. Savin (*J. sabina*) is toxic and a powerful abortifacient. The Japanese *J. rigida* is used as a diuretic.

Cautions Do not use juniper during pregnancy or if prone to heavy menstrual bleeding. Do not take if suffering from a kidney infection or kidney disease. Do not take the essential oil internally except under professional supervision.

Self-help Use Urinary infections, p. 314.

K. pinnata syn. *K. africana*
(Bignoniaceae)

Kigelia, African Sausage Tree

Description Semi-deciduous tree growing to 80 ft (25 m) with smooth, gray-brown bark and brown-purple flowers. The tree gets its name from the spectacular sausage-shaped fruit, up to 3 ft (1 m) in length, which hangs from a rope-like stalk and weighs up to 22 lb (10 kg).

Habitat & Cultivation *Kigelia* grows throughout sub-Saharan Africa but is native to the eastern half of the continent from Tanzania to South Africa. The tree is cultivated from seed or cuttings and flowers after 6 years. The fruit is harvested when ripe.

Parts Used Fruit pulp, leaves, bark, roots.

Constituents *Kigelia* fruit contains norviburtinal, coumarins, iridoids, flavonoids, fatty acids, sterols, glycosides, and naphthaquinones. Norviburtinal has tumor-reducing activity, the iridoids and sterols are anti-inflammatory, the flavonoids are antifungal, and the naphthaquinones are thought to be cytotoxic.

History & Folklore Prized by traditional healers throughout sub-Saharan Africa, *kigelia* has been put to many uses. The Shona of southern Africa use the bark or root to treat skin infections and ulcers, toothache, backache, and pneumonia. In Central Africa, the unripe fruit is used as a dressing for wounds, hemorrhoids, and rheumatism.

In West Africa, the leaves are given for stomach and kidney problems, and the fruit is used as a purgative and applied as a paste to sores. *Kigelia* is commonly included in traditional herbal formulations for malaria.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Thanks to the knowledge and experience of African traditional healers, *kigelia* is now understood to be a valuable remedy for skin problems, particularly sores and ulcers, produced by bacterial and fungal infection. *Kigelia* has been described as a "natural antibacterial." Given its marked anti-inflammatory and wound healing properties, *kigelia* is also being investigated as a skin toner and restorer, as well as potential treatment for skin disorders such as eczema, psoriasis, and solar keratosis (a precancerous skin problem caused by overexposure to sunlight). Various patents exist for *kigelia* products, and over time *kigelia* may become widely known as a key herbal resource for the skin.



Kigelia is a key remedy for treating skin problems.

⚠ Cautions Take *kigelia* internally only under professional guidance. Do not take during pregnancy or while breastfeeding.

Krameria triandra (Krameriaceae) Rhatany

Description Dense evergreen shrub growing to 3 ft (90 cm). Has a deep root, oblong leaves, and large red flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Rhatany is found in Ecuador, Peru, and Bolivia on western slopes of the Andes at altitudes of 3,000–9,800 ft (900–3,000 m). The root is unearthed throughout the year.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Rhatany contains 10–20% tannins, including phlobaphene, benzofurans, and n-methyltyrosine.

History & Folklore A traditional South American remedy, rhatany was used by indigenous peoples as an astringent and a tooth preservative. Its Spanish name, *raiz para los dientes* (root for the teeth), points to this traditional usage.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Rhatany is astringent and antimicrobial. It is a useful remedy taken principally for problems affecting the gastrointestinal tract. It is most commonly used for diarrhea and dysentery. In addition, rhatany makes a good mouthwash and gargle for bleeding and infected gums, mouth ulcers, and sore throats. The plant's astringency makes it useful in the form of an ointment, suppository, or wash for treating hemorrhoids. Rhatany may also be applied to wounds to help staunch blood flow, to varicose veins, and over areas of capillary fragility that may be prone to easy bruising.

Related Species The Mexican *K. cystisoides* is an astringent remedy used in much the same way as rhatany. Another species native to North and Central America, *K. parvifolia*, was used by the Papago as an eyewash.

Lactuca virosa (Lamiaceae) Wild Lettuce

Description Hollow-stemmed biennial growing to about 4 ft (1.2 m). Has broad spiny leaves and clusters of pale yellow composite flowers. All parts of the plant exude a white milky latex.

Habitat & Cultivation Common throughout Europe, wild lettuce grows in open areas, along roadsides, and in hedges. It is gathered when in flower in late summer.

Parts Used Leaves, latex, seeds.

Constituents The latex contains sesquiterpene lactones (including lactucopicrin and lactucerin);